

Ophelia

A SHORT FILM BY LANE HAVEN



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Synopsis

"Ophelia" follows River, a withdrawn college student grappling with the recent death of his sister Sarah, a passionate actor who once anchored his world. When he reluctantly joins a theatre class she loved, River is paired with Jo, an ambitious and sharp-tongued actor determined to land a lead role. As they rehearse scenes from Hamlet, River's buried grief begins to surface—blurring the line between performance and reality.

Through Jo's persistence and the emotional demands of acting, River is forced to confront his loss rather than avoid it. What begins as obligation evolves into a deeply personal journey of healing, as River learns that true performance requires vulnerability—and that letting go doesn't mean losing connection to her. In a final audition that intertwines memory and presence, River steps fully into himself, honoring his sister not by holding on, but by moving forward.

World of Play

- Set on a college campus in 1996. An underfunded Dramatic Arts program becomes home for our protagonist - just the place that fosters great art
- Tone is grounded, and character driven, with certain moments of surreal imagery depicting themes through metaphor.



Comps

ORDINARY PEOPLE

A kid struggling with loss, seeking help but not knowing how to ask.



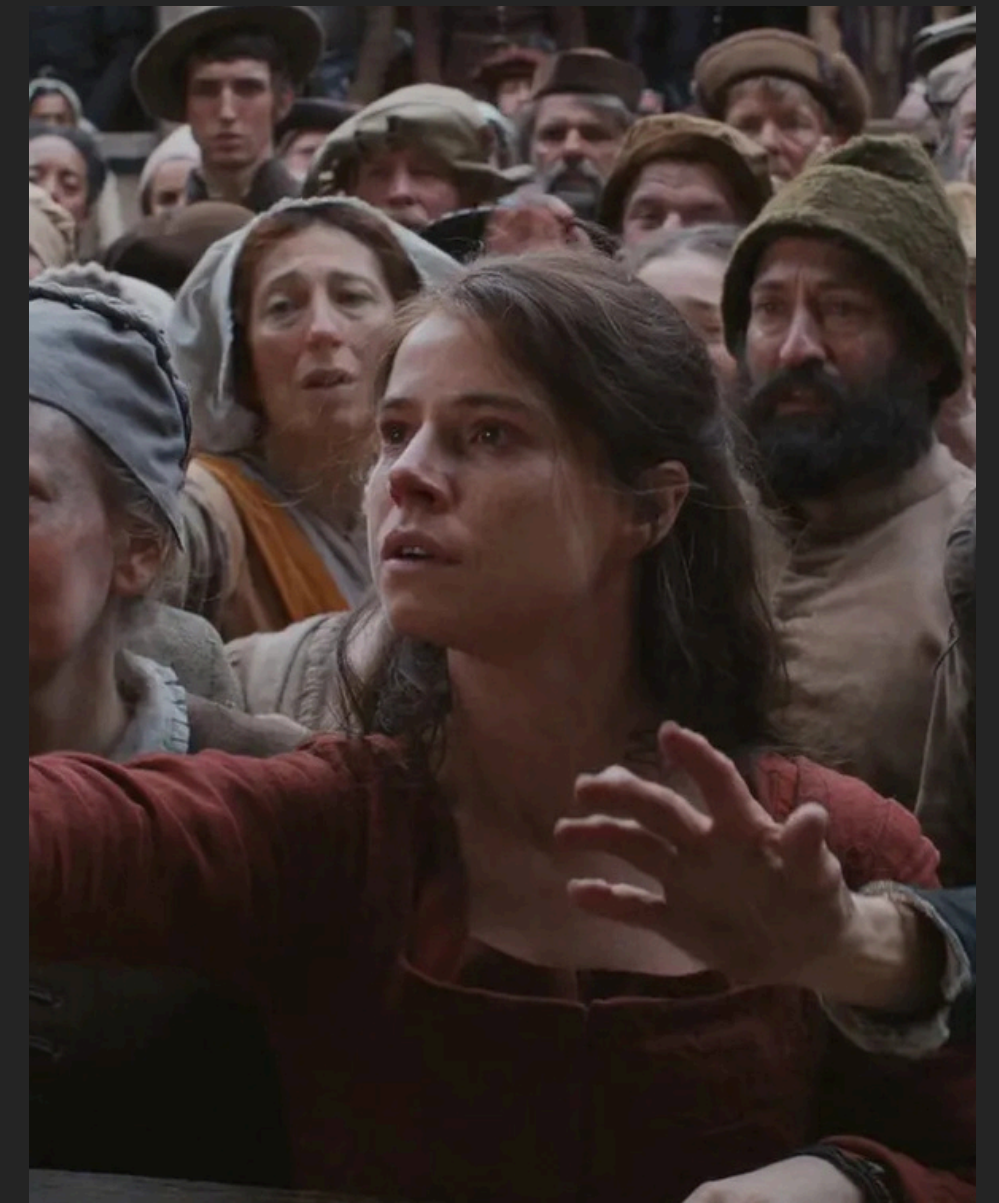
DEAD POETS SOCIETY

The community of academia and theatre. Very close visual comp.



HAMNET

Theatre as therapy.



Characters...

River

(20) A withdrawn, emotionally fractured college student navigating grief after the loss of his sister. Initially detached and resistant, he is pulled into acting as a way to process memory, identity, and pain—blurring the line between performance and reality.



Characters...

Sarah

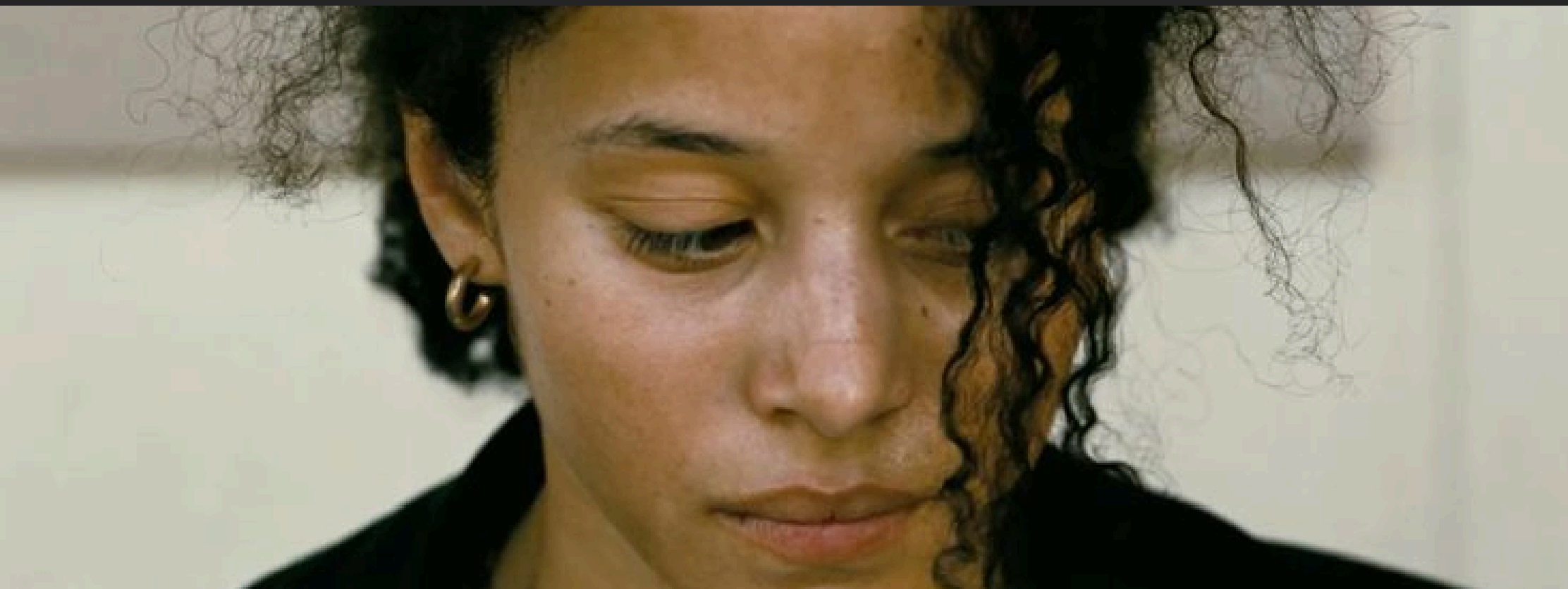
(22) River's older sister—vibrant, passionate, and deeply committed to her craft. Seen through memory and flashback, she represents both inspiration and unresolved loss, leaving behind a presence that continues to shape River's emotional world.



Characters...

Jo

(20) Driven, sharp, and unapologetically ambitious, Jo sees acting as her path forward. Beneath her assertiveness is a grounded emotional intelligence—she becomes both a creative partner and emotional counterbalance to River, pushing him toward honesty and vulnerability.



Characters...

Professor Morris

(60's) An enigmatic and intuitive acting teacher with an almost spiritual presence. She challenges her students to confront truth rather than perform it, acting as a quiet catalyst for River's internal transformation.



General Beauty"

A person is sitting on a circular platform made of straw or hay. The platform is surrounded by a large, rustic, circular frame made of twigs and branches. The scene is set against a dark background, and the lighting is warm, highlighting the person and the platform.

"Some actors spend their whole lives indicating feeling rather than experiencing. This is phony." -William Ball

What if everyone acted how they truly felt? Sometimes the truth hurts. Sometimes the truth hurts another.

"Ophelia" explores the beauty of exploring the truth in oneself through the medium of acting

Director's Vision

"Ophelia is a stage where loss performs itself night after night, even after the audience has gone home".

I want to make theatre *look cool*, increasing accessibility to a larger audience.
Reimagined through a modern lense, and
Inspired by the evocative power of live theatre, I want this film to move people in the way that breaths, lives and flows like theatre

